

What else to watch: *Kwaidan* (1964) ■ *Poltergeist* (1982) ■ *Ghost Actress* (1996) ■ *Rasen* (1998) ■ *Kairo* (2001) ■ *Dark Water* (2002) ■ *One Missed Call* (2003) ■ *Ju-on: The Grudge* (2004) ■ *Pulse* (2006) ■ *It Follows* (2014)



The teen-horror element initially seems to be a misdirect, since *Ringu* quite quickly becomes a detective yarn, with journalist Reiko (Nanako Matsushima) becoming interested in the case after discovering that her niece is one of the latest victims. Retracing the girl's final steps, Reiko finds the videotape and watches it. She then has seven days to avert her own death—a race against time to decipher the mysterious imagery she has seen. By chance, Reiko's teenage son watches the tape too, raising the stakes even higher.

Ghosts of the past

With Reiko inching closer to solving the mystery, it almost seems as though Nakata is going to abandon the horror element altogether, as Reiko begins to piece together the story of a famous psychic who lost her powers when her daughter, Sadako (Rie Inô), was born. For a

time, the story winds back into the past to uncover the terrible secrets that have begun to seep into the present.

As with other Japanese horrors that *Ringu* later inspired, there is a prospect of redemption; although she is clearly a malevolent spirit, Sadako (and Okiku in the original folktale) has a sympathetic

Reiko, a journalist, stares at the static that marks the end of the deadly videotape. Within moments, her phone will ring and a mysterious voice will tell her of her fate.

backstory, and so the focus switches from the untimely deaths of teenagers to Reiko's attempt to right the injustice done to Sadako in the past and lift her curse. And yet there are virtuoso moments of goose-bump horror to come, and images that will haunt the viewer long after watching this movie. Although Hollywood produced a watchable remake in 2002, it could not inspire the same dread.

The figure of Sadako became an instant icon and influenced a whole genre. The imagery is based on Japanese *yurei* ghosts: she has a pale face and long, matted hair, suggesting that her corpse received no burial rites (Japanese women were traditionally buried with their hair up, not down). In this, the movie explores the clash of ancient folktale and Japanese modernity, with the ghost's terror hiding in something as prosaic as a videotape. ■



Hideo Nakata Director

Born in rural Okayama in 1961, Hideo Nakata worked for seven years

as an assistant director before making his debut with the 1996 fantasy-horror *Don't Look Up* (or *Ghost Actress*). He secured his reputation internationally with *Ringu*, switching the gender of the protagonist in the tale on which it is based. *Ringu* ushered

in a new genre of Japanese horror—J-horror—in which female leads are stalked by the ghosts of young girls. He continued the formula with 2002's *Dark Water*.

Key movies

1996 *Don't Look Up*
1998 *Ringu*
1999 *Ringu 2*
2002 *Dark Water*